BRAIN 09

Piracetam

Small synthetic molecule (2-oxo-1-pyrrolidine acetamide), the first of the “racetams”; not a peptide



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Small molecule (racetam)	Dementia, memory, stroke, myoclonus	Controlled human trials; reviews disagree	Not FDA approved

STUDIED FOR

Dementia	Memory problems	Acute stroke
HUMAN	HUMAN	HUMAN

Cortical myoclonus	Blood flow factors
HUMAN	HUMAN + ANIMAL

Reviews disagree. A maker-funded analysis found a global benefit; Cochrane (2001) and a 2024 review found no clear effect on memory or thinking.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Piracetam ▶ Platelets ▶ Blood flow ▶ Brain function

- **UK label:** its action in cortical myoclonus is unknown
- **Label:** makes red cells more flexible and reduces platelet clumping
- **In healthy volunteers,** high doses lowered fibrinogen and von Willebrand factor
- **For memory in people,** the mechanism is not established

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

CONTROLLED TRIALS
LEVEL 4 OF 5

- Many placebo-controlled trials in dementia, stroke
- 676-person MCI trial: no results posted
- Approved in UK, Belgium, Luxembourg; not US

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Effect on memory (2024 review)
- Effect in dementia
- Effects in healthy men

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE	ROUTES STUDIED
5.0 hours in young adult men (UK label)	By mouth (tablets) on the UK label
PHARMACOKINETICS	**SOLD AS**
Almost fully absorbed; no metabolite found; excreted in urine	Not FDA approved; FDA cited supplements containing it (2019)
MONITORED IN TRIALS	**SPORT (WADA)**
Kidney function; bleeding risk (UK label)	Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Not approved; 503A/503B Category 3
MHRA	Licensed (Nootropil) for cortical myoclonus
TGA	Prescription-only (Schedule 4); not authorised
WADA	Not named; relative fonturacetam is S6.A

REFERENCES

1. MHRA (emc), Nootropil 1200 mg UK SmPC, Jul 2025
2. FDA, bulk drug substances nominated under section 503B (categories), Mar 2025
3. Clin Neurol Neurosurg, piracetam and memory meta-analysis, Aug 2024

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